Provincial Mentoring

Provincial Grand Lodge of Hertfordshire

Prepare • Guide • Support • Enlighten

Lodge Mentor Essentials

One hour on the five things that change what a Lodge Mentor does on Monday

Delivered by W Bro Wes Pierce, Deputy Provincial Grand Mentor

The hour

1 Why mentoring

7 min

2 The role: organiser, not everything

15 min

3 Principles and the two windows

8 min

4 Your first month

8 min

5 When it gets difficult

10 min

6 The Province, your plan, the Charge

12 min

Why mentoring

A good man, lost because nobody noticed.

The Hertfordshire answer

Freemasonry must be fun. A man who is enjoying himself attends; a man who attends participates; a man who participates belongs; and a man who belongs does not resign.

Retention is an outcome

Of culture, never a target. Where someone finally asks why, one resignation in three is recovered. Where nobody asks, none are.

Organiser, not everything

The Lodge Mentor

- Makes sure mentoring happens; does not do it all himself
- Assigns a Personal Mentor to every new and joining member, promptly
- Supports his Personal Mentors and equips them
- Opens and reviews a Personal Mentoring Plan for each member
- Watches for patterns and acts early
- The Lodge's link to the Province; briefs the Lodge once a year
- Three to five years; develops his successor from day one

Not the Lodge Mentor

- Personal Mentor to everyone. Share the work
- The ritual coach. That is the Lodge of Instruction and the DC
- The Almoner. Welfare is his; you refer to him
- An inspector or a report-writer on members
- A one-year office

Choosing a Personal Mentor

Choose for

- Time
- Temperament: a patient listener
- The potential for friendship
- Knows the Lodge well
- Can say “I don’t know, but I’ll find out”

Not for

- Seniority
- Rank
- Being the Proposer, by default. Consider him first; trust exists. But not always
- Being free on the night

Often overlooked

- Past Masters: excellent mentors who often need the purpose
- Joining members with experience from elsewhere
- The quiet Master Mason of ten years who has never been asked
- Give each one the Personal Mentor’s Short Guide the day you ask

Exercise: who could mentor?

On your own · 3 min

List every member of your Lodge who could be a Personal Mentor. Everyone. Past Masters included.

Action Plan sheet, box 1

Three minutes writing. Then a number from each person round the room.

What you will find

The list is always longer than you expected. The question is not whether your Lodge has the people; it is whether anyone has asked them.

The four principles

Defined once on the canon page and quoted everywhere. They run together, all the time. They are not stages.

1 PREPARE

Ready for each stage before it happens. There should never be any surprises.

2 GUIDE

Accurate, honest, timely information. Never dependency.

3 SUPPORT

Present, responsive, compassionate. “How can we help?”, never “Why aren’t you attending?”

4 ENLIGHTEN

Understanding, curiosity and enjoyment of Freemasonry, for life.

Family, Work, Masonry: in that order, always.

The journey, and the two windows

1. Enquiry to Initiation
2. Entered Apprentice
3. Fellow Craft
4. Master Mason
5. Office and the Chair
6. Beyond the Chair

Risk window 1: the first two years, often before Raising

Risk window 2: the year after the Chair

Spring Initiates

The summer break interrupts their early participation. Plan deliberate summer contact and a social touchpoint for every one of them.

Past Masters

Included, Involved, Interested: a role, a project, a Brother to mentor. Prepare the Master Elect for after the Chair from Installation day.

Your first month: six things

1 Ask for your induction

If you have not had it. It comes with the Charge and the Mentor's Jewel.

2 Get the list

From the Secretary: candidates, members in their first two years, joining members in their first year. These are the men under mentoring.

3 Mentor and Plan for every man on it

Where there is a gap, fill it this month, not next.

4 Ten minutes each

Secretary, Almoner, Worshipful Master. Agree the attendance record after every meeting, same-day notice of any resignation, and your report on the Committee agenda.

5 Join the monthly call

First Tuesday, 7pm, Teams. Open to you and every Personal Mentor.

6 Invite your APGMen

To the next Initiation. He is there to help, never to inspect.

When it gets difficult

The pattern is the signal

- A break in his own pattern, not a low level of attendance. The stalwart who stops coming is the one to worry about
- The Secretary's attendance record is your early-warning system
- Two misses, seven days: the habit

The hand-offs

- Almoner: anything touching welfare. Note only "referred to Almoner"
- Secretary: acknowledges a resignation only; cannot accept it; you and the Almoner told the same day
- Treasurer: a first missed subscription earns a quiet word
- Royal Arch Representative: One Journey's bridge

1 Personal Mentor

Warm, informal. After two misses, within seven days of the second.

2 You

The overview; what could the Lodge change; a discreet note; close the loop.

3 Worshipful Master

Lodge culture, office or another member. Almoner alongside for welfare.

4 The Province

An impartial voice, or a Lodge where he might thrive. A strength, not a failure.

Pressure, in both directions

The member pushed too hard

- Office before he feels ready or confident
- Ritual beyond his current ability
- Progression faster than he wishes
- The Royal Arch or other orders before the time is right
- Anything that makes him feel inadequate, unwelcome or judged
- “Sink or swim” runs counter to UGLE guidance. Address it directly; escalate if needed

The member left under-stretched

- A capable Brother waiting years for a first office
- A Brother who was never asked: to visit, to take a small piece, to help
- A Past Master with nothing to do; a joining member whose experience nobody used
- A Master Mason of years who stopped learning because nobody offered
- Ask what he would like; find a role; raise the office queue with the Master and DC
- A bored Brother leaves as surely as a frightened one

The Province behind you

Your APGMen

One per area. Advice, a visitor at Initiations, your quarterly update.

Monthly mentoring call

First Tuesday, 7pm, Teams. Lodge Mentors and Personal Mentors.

DAWG

The Daily Advancement WhatsApp Group, run by the Provincial Mentoring Team.

Training

Induction for you; the Personal Mentor course for your team. Send them.

The library

Short Guides, Meeting Guide, Stage Checklists, Warning Signs card, Retention Guide. Provincial website and your APGMen.

One-to-one, in confidence

mentor@hertfordshirefreemasons.org.uk. A difficult conversation, a second opinion, or simply to think aloud.

Your action plan

On your own · 3 min

Against the four principles

One thing my Lodge already does well. One thing it does not do at all. Action Plan sheet, box 2.

The one action

What, by when, and who else needs to know. Box 4. Then one sentence each, round the room.

Your Assistant Provincial Grand Mentor will ask you about it within the month. That is the point.

The Charge

Brother, the office you have accepted is unlike any other in the Lodge... Your duty is not to mentor every member yourself. It is to make sure that every member is mentored.

Read in full from the facilitator guide. Presented in writing to every new Lodge Mentor on appointment.

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Family, Work, Masonry: in that order, always. May the work be patient and purposeful, and may Freemasonry flourish, root and branch. Thank you.